

OSTEOARTHRITIS

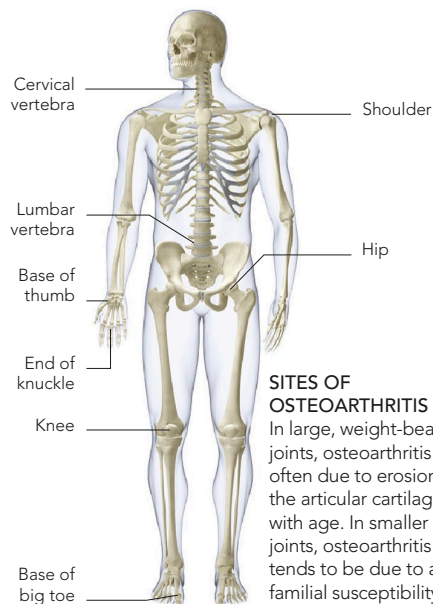
Osteoarthritis is often confused with rheumatoid arthritis (see opposite), but the two disorders have different causes and progressions. Osteoarthritis may affect only a single joint and can be triggered by localized wear and tear, resulting in painful inflammation from time to time. Joint degeneration may be hastened by a congenital defect, injury, infection, or obesity. Because cartilage normally wears away as the body ages, a mild form of osteoarthritis affects many people after about the age of 60 years. Typical symptoms of osteoarthritis include pain and swelling in the affected joint that worsen with activity and fade with rest; joint

stiffness for a short time after rest; restricted movement of the joint; crepitus (crackling noises) when moving the joint; and referred pain (pain in areas remote from the site of damage but on the same nerve pathway as the affected joint).



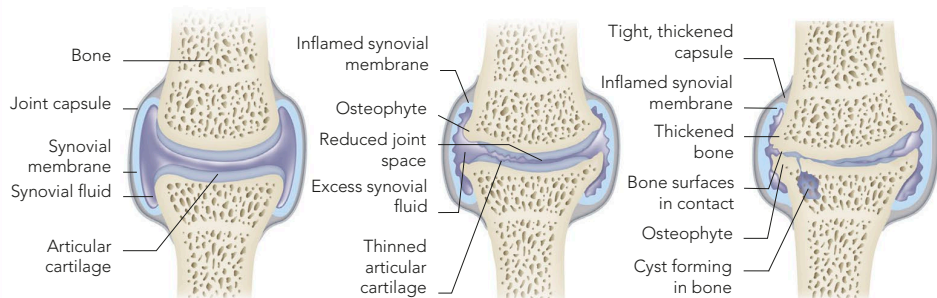
OSTEOARTHRITIS OF THE HIP

The right hip, on the left of this X-ray, is badly eroded by osteoarthritis. The head of the femur, which is normally round, is flattened.



SITES OF OSTEOARTHRITIS

In large, weight-bearing joints, osteoarthritis is often due to erosion of the articular cartilage with age. In smaller joints, osteoarthritis tends to be due to a familial susceptibility.



HEALTHY JOINT

The articular cartilages coating the ends of the bones are smooth and compressible. They are lubricated by synovial fluid and slip past each other with minimal friction.

EARLY OSTEOARTHRITIS

The articular cartilage becomes thin and rough, with fissures in its surface. Bony outgrowths (osteophytes) form, and the synovial lining is inflamed, producing excess fluid.

LATE OSTEOARTHRITIS

The articular cartilage and underlying bone crack and erode. The bones rub together, thicken, and overgrow, causing extreme discomfort. The joint capsule thickens.